

better interface. Evidently, there is still some optimisation that needs to be done to bring the scan-time at higher resolutions to an acceptable level.

Price is also playing fair with hopeful buyers of these machines. We received scanners for as low as Rs 3,499 to as high as 24,999—both the cheapest and the costliest scanners were from HP. The maximum number of scanners came from UMAX—seven scanners, ranging from Rs 3,900 to Rs 15,950. Only HP came close to this with a variety of six models.

Home user

This category consists of those among us for whom price is of great importance—speed comes next, followed closely by features and after-sales support. Entry-level scanners available in the market right now are capable of scanning a document at the respectable resolutions of 600 x 1200 dpi. The resolution of 600 dpi is enough even for scanning a passport-photo size image, which can then be enlarged and printed on an A4-size paper, using a photo printer. Thus, tests with a 600 dpi resolution were awarded greater weightage within this category. The other good news is that scanners now sport the easy-to-use USB 2.0 interface which makes installation hassle-free. Keeping these factors in mind, we formed the benchmarks. They included, the speed test (awarded 40 per cent of weightage), features (awarded 15 per cent, because it is not much of a necessity) and the OCR test (awarded just 7 per cent, as it is not done by everyone actively). All scanners that scored above 60 STTI and cost between Rs 3,000 and Rs 3,900, were considered ideal candidates for this application area.

The best scanner for the home user

The reason behind establishing a home user category was the price factor. Home users, as a trend, are not willing to spend anything upwards of Rs 4,000 for a scanner because of the limited use of these devices. Users of this category would also like

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When you Need to Read the Lines (Not Between Them)



OCR or Optical Character Recognition is a means of obtaining editable text from a scanned medium, such as a newspaper clipping or your friend's college assignment. What follows are a few tips and pointers to better scan a document for the further purpose of OCRing it. Read on:

1. Always opt for a scanner with a white sheet under the lid. This will give more accurate results.
2. Always keep the document flat and ensure that there are no wrinkles or folded corners, as this will produce an image with a black mark in that particular area.
3. Look out for a scanner with software driver that offers de-skew and de-speckle options. This will give more accurately scanned images and hence increase the accuracy of an OCR-software.
4. Do not scan a document with black fonts on a white background in line-art mode, this will return very poor results that will not improve, even by increasing the resolution. Use grayscale mode instead.
5. 200 dpi and 48-bit setting are more than enough for most new OCR software. Increase the resolution to 300 dpi if the document has an image and the format needs to be preserved.